

WC2026 Friends Pool - Rules

Everyone drafts teams from three odds-tiered pots. Your teams earn (and lose) points across the whole tournament from the categories below. Most points at the end wins. The pool leans into chaos - plenty of ways to score are deliberately perverse, so read carefully.

Goals & shots

Event	Points
Open-play goal	+0.5 each
Free-kick goal	doubles the OPPONENT team's points for that game (scores nothing for you)
Penalty scored - not a shootout	-1.5 each
Penalty scored - in a shootout	-0.5 each
Goal ruled out by VAR	-1 each
0 shots on target in a game	+4
Goal scored OR conceded in the 23rd or 67th minute	+4 (max +4 per game, even if you own both teams)
Each game your team fails to score (clean sheet against you)	-1 (own both teams & it's 0-0 = 0; extra time excluded)
Prime number of total goals in the tournament (excludes shootout goals)	-3

A free-kick goal still counts toward your team's total-goals tally (so it can still trigger the prime -3 and the fewest-goals award) - it just earns you nothing directly.

The 90'+ rule

- A goal scored at 90:00 or later multiplies ALL of that team's points for that game by -1.
- Two 90'+ goals in the same game cancel out ($\times -1 \times -1 =$ back to positive).
- In-game points flip in ANY game (win or lose).
- Progression points only flip in your ELIMINATION game. Winning teams bank no progression at that moment, so a champion's Winner points are always safe - but a runner-up who scores a 90'+ goal in the final they lose flips their +8 to -8.

Red card - roll the dice

- When one of your teams gets a red card, roll a single d6.
- Odd roll -> you GAIN (roll / 2) points: 1 = +0.5, 3 = +1.5, 5 = +2.5
- Even roll -> you LOSE (roll / 2) points: 2 = -1, 4 = -2, 6 = -3
- No rounding - half-points stand.

Ranked categories

Each category ranks the top 6 teams across the whole tournament. Positive categories pay 10 / 8 / 5 / 3 / 2 / 1; penalty categories pay the negative of that.

Direction	Points (top 6)	Categories
Reward	10 / 8 / 5 / 3 / 2 / 1	Quickest Goal · Youngest Goalscorer · Fastest Substitute · Fastest Own Goal · Quickest Yellow Card · Longest-Named Goalscorer
Penalty	-10 / -8 / -5 / -3 / -2 / -1	Oldest Goalscorer · Shortest-Named Goalscorer

- An owner can only win a given category once - if you own both the best and second-best team in it, the second prize rolls down to the next DISTINCT owner.
- Ties split the points between the tied owners (owning several tied teams = a bigger share).
- Tiebreak: the most recent occurrence ranks higher.
- Data source priority: official FIFA, else BBC, else ITV.

Flat awards

- Fewest Goals (whole tournament): +7 to the single team with fewest (tie-split between owners).
- Fewest Cards (whole tournament): +7 to the single team with fewest (tie-split between owners).

Tournament progression

Points for the furthest stage a team reaches, realised in the game they're eliminated.

R32	R16	QF	SF	Runner-up	Winner
+1	+2	+3	+5	+8	+10

- 3rd-place playoff WINNER: -5 (cancels their SF +5, so 3rd place nets 0).
- 4th place (loses the 3rd-place playoff): keeps the SF +5.

The draft - pots

16 players. Each player drafts THREE teams - one from each pot - so every squad gets a strong team, a mid team and a long shot (16 players x 3 = the full 48). The pots are seeded by each team's "to reach the quarter-finals" odds: Pot 1 is the 16 strongest, Pot 3 the 16 longest shots.

Pot 1 - strongest	Pot 2 - middle	Pot 3 - long shots
Spain	Japan	Australia
France	Uruguay	Ghana
England	Ecuador	South Africa
Argentina	Croatia	Panama
Portugal	Canada	DR Congo
Brazil	Senegal	Saudi Arabia
Netherlands	Austria	Tunisia
Belgium	Paraguay	Uzbekistan
Germany	Sweden	New Zealand
Norway	Ivory Coast	Cape Verde
Colombia	Egypt	Jordan
USA	Czechia	Iraq
Switzerland	South Korea	Haiti
Mexico	Scotland	Qatar

Pot 1 - strongest	Pot 2 - middle	Pot 3 - long shots
Morocco	Algeria	Curaçao
Turkey	Bosnia & Herzegovina	Iran

Rules locked from the conversation of June 2026. If anything here doesn't match what you expected, flag it before the draft.